From Access to Innovation

The Bayer Pharmaceuticals India chief is looking to expand the portfolio and strengthen the country's contribution to global drug development

BY **NEETU CHANDRA SHARMA**

SHWETA RAI, MANAGING Director—India and Country Division Head—South Asia, for Bayer Pharmaceuticals, is focusing on new product launches, driving access, and clinical research as she charts the company's next phase in India. Bayer's pharmaceutical business in the country has recorded a compound annual growth rate of over 30%, according to the company. "Over the next 12–18 months, we aim to keep the momentum strong through new launches and portfolio expansion," Rai says.

Bayer's partnerships with Indian drugmakers, including Sun Pharmaceutical Industries and Dr Reddy's Laboratories, are part of the company's strategy to widen access to some of its medicines.

Rai identifies cardiovascular, renal, and metabolic diseases, oncology and women's healthcare as areas of opportunity, given India's disease burden. The company is also using AI-enabled productivity tools and Bayer's Dynamic Shared Ownership operating model to help teams make decisions faster and strengthen execution.

A key priority is India's contribution to global drug development.

"Strengthening research collaborations, leveraging India's scientific expertise and integrating local capabilities into our global innovation network will remain central to our growth strategy," Rai says.

With 25 years of experience in healthcare, Rai has previously worked at Johnson & Johnson, MSD Pharmaceuticals, IQVIA and Pfizer.

She joined Bayer in 2019 and became Managing Director of its India pharmaceutical business in January 2024.

Her priorities include expanding the company's portfolio and increasing access while drawing more on India's research capabilities. BT

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SHWETA RAI
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